

Toward a More Perfect Union

Modern America • 1964–Present | Standards US.83, US.84, US.85, US.86, US.87, US.88, US.89, US.90, US.91, US.92, US.93, US.94, US.95

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

This is the last stop, and it runs right up to your own front door. In sixty years America argued about almost everything — how big government should be, whether it could be trusted, what it owed the poor and the planet, how to keep itself safe, and who was allowed to lead. It broke a president, ended a Cold War, was attacked on its own soil, and elected a Black president in the same century a Tennessee balcony took the movement's greatest leader. After 130 years of watching the gap between America's promise and its practice, the last question is the one only you can answer: is the union still becoming more perfect — and what will you do with it?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories.

Great Society _____

counterculture _____

Watergate _____

stagflation _____

Reaganomics _____

War on Terror _____

the tech revolution _____

a more perfect union _____

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Your read & evidence
1	Analyze Johnson's Great Society and the 1960s counterculture as two very different responses to the question of what America should become. Notice: Two revolutions at once. In Washington, a president tries to build a 'Great Society' — declaring war on poverty itself and creating health care... Debrief: Describe two major programs of the Great Society and their goals. Then explain what the 'generation gap' and counterculture were rejecting. How were these two 1960s movements different visions of America's future?	
2	Analyze Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and China opening, and the Watergate scandal that proved no one is above the law. Notice: A president pulls off one of the boldest moves in the history of American diplomacy — flying to communist China to shake the hand of a man his... Debrief: Explain Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and his opening to China. Then explain what Watergate was and why United States v. Nixon mattered. What does Watergate teach about limits on presidential power?	
3	Analyze the rise of the modern environmental movement and its landmark laws and conflicts. Notice: A river so polluted it literally caught fire. A book that revealed the pesticides in your food were killing the birds. A neighborhood built on a... Debrief: Explain what sparked the modern environmental movement and describe two laws or agencies it created. Then explain the conflict the snail-darter case revealed. Why might environmental protection sometimes clash with other goals?	
4	Analyze Carter's presidency — stagflation and the energy crisis, the Camp David triumph, and the Iran Hostage Crisis. Notice: Imagine prices going up AND jobs disappearing at the same time — the two things that aren't supposed to happen together, both happening at once.... Debrief: Explain what 'stagflation' and the energy crisis were and how they affected Americans. Then contrast Carter's greatest success (Camp David) with his greatest failure (Iran). Was Carter's reputation as a 'failed' president fair? Defend your answer.	
5	Analyze the Reagan Revolution — its economic policy, its social costs and conflicts, and its Cold War pressure on the Soviet Union. Notice: After a decade of gas lines, hostages, and self-doubt, a former movie actor stood up and told Americans it was 'Morning in America' again — that... Debrief: Explain 'Reaganomics' and one result of it. Describe Reagan's approach to the Cold War. Then identify one social cost or conflict of the Reagan era. Why is it important to weigh both sides of this presidency?	
6	Analyze how George H.W. Bush managed the peaceful end of the Cold War and led a coalition in the Gulf War. Notice: The wall came down. The enemy America had feared for 45 years — the one with thousands of nuclear missiles aimed at your grandparents — simply... Debrief: Explain how the Cold War ended under Bush and why his restraint mattered. Then describe the Gulf War and Bush's coalition-building approach. Why was leaving Saddam Hussein in power a debated decision?	
7	Analyze the Clinton-era economy and the communication-technology revolution that reshaped how Americans live. Notice: Somewhere in the 1990s, the whole world moved into your pocket. In a single generation, America went from landlines, letters, and encyclopedias on... Debrief: Describe how communication technology changed from the 1970s to today, with two examples, including one benefit and one challenge. Then explain the Clinton-era economy and the debate over NAFTA. How did technology and the economy connect?	
8	Analyze the September 11, 2001 attacks and the War on Terror they set in motion. Notice: On an ordinary bright Tuesday morning, the country you've been studying for ten units was attacked at home — not by an army, but by nineteen men... Debrief: Explain what happened on September 11, 2001, and how the United States responded. Then explain the debate the USA PATRIOT Act raised. How does that	

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Your read & evidence
	debate connect to earlier moments in this course?	
9	Analyze the breaking of barriers for women and minorities in government, culminating in the election of the first African American president — and... Notice: Go back to Unit 1. In 1877, a Black Southerner couldn't safely vote, a woman couldn't vote at all, and the idea of either one leading the country... Debrief: Give three examples of women or minorities breaking barriers in government. Then explain why Obama's 2008 election was historic, and its context. Finally: looking across the whole course from 1877 to 2009, has the country moved closer to 'a more perfect union'? Defend your answer with evidence from at least two units.	

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 10 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **President Johnson signs Medicare and Medicaid into law in 1965 (with former President Truman beside him) — a cornerstone of the Great Society.**

- Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?

- Spark's question: *This is President Johnson signing Medicare in 1965, with former President Truman — who had tried and failed to pass health insurance — beside him....*

- What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Toward ↗ or away ↘?	Why — your evidence
1965	The Great Society builds a safety net		
1974	Watergate: the system holds		
1970	The environmental movement wins protection		
1991	The Cold War ends peacefully		
2001	The September 11 attacks		
2009	The first African American president		

B Debrief & Closing Argument

This is where the whole course comes home. For ten units and 130 years, you've measured America against its own founding promise — 'a more perfect...

Closing question: You've now traveled the entire arc, from 1877 to today. Looking back across all ten units, argue whether the United States has, on balance, moved closer to its founding promise of 'a more perfect union' — using at least three moments from different units as evidence. Then, because this is your country now: name one part of the promise you think is still unfinished, and one thing your generation could do about it. There's no answer key. This one is yours to write.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:
